located at the center of the hexagon in an arrangement shaped somewhat like a Star of David. There were eight such sites on the island, each preparing to deploy six missile launchers. Since the U-2 cameras could not discern all the territory of Cuba because of partial cloud cover, that was probably not a complete tally of the missiles deployed there. All the spotted missile sites were in western Cuba, closer to Florida and the mainland United States. Unbeknownst to CIA experts, they belonged to the 12th Dnipropetrovsk Antiaircraft Division, which had begun its deployment on the island back in July.[2]

Kennedy knew that he had a problem on his hands. The most immediate one was political rather than military. The CIA report played right into the hands of Kennedy's Republican opponents, who were ready to turn Cuba into a key election issue in the forthcoming November congressional elections. Media reports about increased Soviet sea traffic to Cuba and the large number of Soviet personnel spotted on the island had already given them enough ammunition to accuse the president of doing nothing about the imminent danger from the island. On the very same day Kennedy received disturbing news from Cuba, Kenneth Keating, a Republican senator from New York, told Congress that "the Soviets are constructing missile bases and sending over technicians and experts to man them." "I am reliably informed—when I say 'reliably informed' I mean that has been checked out from five different sources," declared Keating.[3]

Keating had been on an antimissile crusade against the administration since December 1961, when Admiral E. J. O'Donnell, the commander of the US naval base in Guantánamo, confided to one of Keating's staffers that he believed missile sites were under construction in Cuba. There had been no evidence to back up such claims at the time, but now, with media reports about Soviets spotted on the island by Cuban refugees seeking safe haven in Florida, Keating was back in the spotlight. "More than 20 cargo ships have arrived from Communist ports in the last few weeks," Keating told Congress. "Many have been unloaded under maximum security. Between three and five thousand so called 'technicians' have arrived in the course of the past year." He concluded his presentation with a call to action: "Time is short. The situation is growing worse. I urge upon my Government that prompt action be taken."[4]